

Question

What is question?

A **sentence** or phrase used to **find out information**.

While developing good questions may seem like a pretty straightforward task, it is not as simple as it looks. A good question needs to have a personality of its own which is made of specific characteristics. Here are some of the most essential characteristics of a good question.

Characteristic of a Good Question:

1. Relevant

A good question is relevant. It focuses on recall of only the material covered in your lesson and aligns well with the overall learning objectives.

If you ask 'What are the branches of soil science?' for an introductory lesson that focused on only the type of soil, then it doesn't really qualify as a relevant question. A better and more relevant question in this context would be 'What are the characteristics of each type of soil?'.

2. Clear

A **good question** is framed in a clear, easily understandable language, without any vagueness. Students should understand what is wanted from the question even when they don't know the answer to it.

3. Concise

A good question is usually crisp and concise. It omits any unnecessary information that requires students to spend time understanding it correctly. The idea is not to trick learners but assess their knowledge.

4. Purposeful

A question without a definite purpose has no value. The purpose helps evaluate the question against some set benchmarks. A good question can seek both innate and specific knowledge.

A question stating ‘What is the capital of France?’ requires the student to just exercise their memory to answer it.

5. Guiding But Not Leading

A good question guides the learners towards understanding the concept in the picture. But at the same time, it doesn’t lead them to specific answers.

6. Stimulates Thinking

A good question requires learners to think through and recall the concepts taught. It doesn’t patronize them by asking the obvious.

‘Can you survive without water?’ is the perfect example of a question that doesn’t stimulate any thinking because questions a universally accepted fact. ‘How long does it take to die from the lack of water?’ might be a better question in this regard.

7. Single-Dimensional

Remember, one question is one question. And hence, a good question focuses on one dimension at a time. If there are multiple ideas to evaluate, it is better to split them into multiple questions.

‘When did World War II begin and why was it fought?’ is a multi-dimensional question that requires students to examine two things at a time. It is recommended to divide it into two distinct questions to facilitate easier and better recall: ‘When did World War II begin?’ and ‘Why was World War II fought?’.

That’s all about good questions, their power, and their characteristics.